

South America



The 12 countries of South America—the world's fourth-largest continent—were colonial outposts of European powers until the early 19th century. A series of wars with local nationalist movements resulted in independence for most of the continent by the 1820s.

Colombia



A state plagued by violence ever since independence, Colombia is slowly stabilizing.

1525 Spain begins the conquest of Colombia, subjugating the Cibcha people who live in Colombia and Panama.

1530s Gonzalo Jiménez de Quesada explores what is now Colombia while searching for the legendary El Dorado.

1717 Santa Fé de Bogota becomes capital of the new Viceroyalty of New Granada.

1811 Independence from Spain is declared in Cundinamarca.

1819 Simón Bolívar—"the Liberator"—defeats the Spanish at Boyacá. Republic of Gran Colombia formed including present-day Venezuela, Ecuador, and Panama.

1830 Venezuela and Ecuador split away during revolts and civil wars. Colombia independent as "New Granada."

1849 The centralist Conservative and federalist Liberal parties are established.

1861–86 Period in which the Liberals hold monopoly on power.

1863 Changes name to United States of Colombia.

Against the state

The combination of left-wing guerrilla groups, such as the M-19, and drug cartels made Colombia one of the world's more dangerous countries in the 1980s and 1990s.

1886–1930 Period of one-party Conservative rule.

1899–1902 Liberal "War of 1,000 Days" revolt fails; 120,000 die.

1903 US helps Panama secede so that it can build the canal across the isthmus; the new country is not recognized by Colombia until 1921.

1930 Liberal President Olaya Herrera is elected by a coalition in the first peaceful change of power.

1946 Conservatives take over.

1948 Shooting of Liberal leader and the subsequent El Bogotazo riot spark civil war lasting until 1957; 300,000 killed.

1953–57 Military dictatorship of Rojas Pinilla.

1958 Conservatives and Liberals agree to alternate government in a National Front until 1974. Other parties are banned.

1965 Left-wing guerrilla movements, the National Liberation Army (ELN) and the Maoist Popular Liberation Army, are formed.

1966 Armed Revolutionary Forces of Colombia (FARC) guerrilla group is formed.

1968 Constitutional reform allows new parties, but two-party parity continues. Guerrilla groups proliferate from now on.

1984 Minister of Justice assassinated for enforcing antidrug campaign.

1985 M-19 guerrillas blast their way into Ministry of Justice; 11 judges

and 90 others are killed. The Patriotic Union (UP) Party is formed.

1986 Liberal Virgilio Barco Vargas wins presidential elections, ending power-sharing. UP wins 11 seats in parliament. Right-wing paramilitary groups start a murder campaign against UP politicians. Violence by both left-wing groups and death squads run by drug cartels continues.

1989 M-19 signs peace agreement with government and becomes a legal party.

1990 UP and PL presidential candidates are murdered. Liberal César Gaviria is elected on an antidrug platform.

1991 New constitution legalizes divorce and prohibits extradition of Colombian nationals. Indigenous peoples' democratic rights are guaranteed, but territorial claims are not addressed.

1992–93 Medellín drug cartel leader Pablo Escobar is captured. He escapes and is shot dead by the police.

1995–96 President Ernesto Samper is cleared of charges of receiving Cali cartel drug funds for elections.

1998 Andrés Pastrana Arango of the Conservative Party succeeds Samper.

2001 US-backed spraying of illegal coca plantations begins in south; destruction of food crops by herbicides provokes resentment among peasant farmers.

2002 Peace talks with FARC and ELN are abandoned, and the military invades the demilitarized haven granted to FARC as part of the peace deal. Right-wing independent candidate Álvaro Uribe Vélez wins the presidential election.

2003 Right-wing paramilitaries United Self-Defense Forces of Colombia (AUC) begin to disarm.

2006 President Uribe wins second four-year term in office.

2009–10 Accusations that the Venezuelans are giving refuge to FARC guerrillas almost lead to open war.

2010 Juan Manuel Santos wins presidential elections.

«230–31 Contact Americas
«280–81 The Slave Trade
«318–19 Latin America Liberated

Venezuela



The first colony to win independence from Spain. Vast reserves of oil have been discovered there.

1498–1500 Columbus sails along the Venezuelan coast on his third voyage. The region is inhabited by Carib, Arawak, and Chibcha peoples.

1777 Venezuela becomes a Captaincy-General within the Spanish Viceroyalty of New Granada.

1806–21 War of Liberation, headed by Simón Bolívar, in which 25 percent of the Venezuelan population dies.

1811 Independence is formally declared, but Venezuela again falls under Spanish rule in 1812.

1813 Bolívar sets up a government in Caracas but is driven out by the Spanish the following year.

1816 Bolívar returns from exile with an expeditionary force and establishes capital at Angostura (now Ciudad Bolívar).

1819 A congress at Angostura establishes Gran Colombia: Venezuela, New Granada (Panama and Colombia), and Ecuador.

1821 Battle of Carabobo overthrows Spanish rule and leads to consolidation of independence within Gran Colombia.

1830 Gran Colombia collapses. José Antonio Páez rules Venezuela; coffee planters are effectively in control.

1870 Antonio Guzmán Blanco comes to power. Construction begins on a new railway system and Guzmán develops agriculture and education.

1902 Venezuela defaults on loans taken out to modernize its infrastructure. Its ports are blockaded by British, Italian, and German warships in response.

1908 General Juan Vicente Gómez becomes dictator. The oil industry is developed and Venezuela becomes world's largest exporter of oil.

1935 Gómez falls from power. Increasing mass participation in political process.

1945 Military coup: Rómulo Betancourt takes power as leader of a civilian-military junta.

1948 Democratic Action Party (AD) wins elections, with novelist Rómulo Gallegos as presidential candidate. A military coup overthrows him and Carlos Delgado Chabaud becomes president with US and military backing.

1958 General strike. Admiral Larrázabal leads a military coup. In free elections, Betancourt, newly returned from exile, wins presidential election for the AD. Anticommunist campaign mounted.

